Cross. There was a moment when it was all working well: we were in a kind of bunker and it looked like a spirit of co-operation had taken hold, although it was sterile when compared to how we put together the Baghdad video. My methods were probably odd to some of them, but we got down to it, myself teaching them to understand the material and clean up the copy, with the *Guardian* people, the *New York Times* in full attendance and *Der Spiegel* coming occasionally. I stayed at the homes of both of the *Guardian* reporters for a while. I was tense and I had to keep moving. But we were getting there, and I wasn't really thinking about the relationships – I thought the material was our relationship – and for a time a spirit of sharing and exploration took over.

I had hoped all along that the papers would share their research with each other, and they honoured that. For instance, one of the early stories I found was on Task Force 373, a US Special Forces assassination squad that was working with a list of 2,000 people. It might sound reasonable enough to people who have watched too many episodes of *Generation Kill*, but this JPL (or Joint Party List) is actually a totally barbaric, extra-judicial nightmare. You saw how people could just get on the list, no judicial review, nothing. Some governor in Afghanistan could just not like you, and nominate you for the JPL, and next minute a drone comes in and bombs your house. With patience and care, you could follow the repercussions of the task force's work through the logs. An entry from 2 May 2007 looked ahead to a meeting with the deputy governor scheduled for the next day. The first item on the agenda was 'discuss repercussions of recent TF 373 ops and address village grievances' and the next item was 'provide relief to the district and the school that was bombed'. Task Force 373 was a secret squad until we named it, and the story made the front page of *Der Spiegel*. Interestingly, according to a source the story about it in the Guardian was partly written by Eric Schmitt of the New York Times. His own paper were alleged not to have had the stomach to publish it.

I was keen, as were others, that the publications should be in sync but that the *New York Times* should steal a march. We felt this would best protect the sources: that the US government were less likely to go for the *New York Times*, and that the paper could effectively use its prestige for strong journalistic ends, on behalf of all the participating bodies. But, true to form, another gleam appeared in the eye of our collaborators: the *New York Times* would prefer that we went first. This was nothing but a piece of